

Chapter-14 Agreement of the Verb with Subject

Read the following sentences carefully.

1. Ram and Sham is friends.
2. I were not there.
3. He like mangoes.
4. All the boys is playing cricket.
5. You is my friend.
6. They has taken their meal.

THINK: Do you notice any abnormality in these sentences?

In each sentence given above, the verb does not agree with the subject in number or person. Now read the same sentences again.

1. Ram and Sham are friends.
2. I was not there.
3. He likes mangoes.
4. All the boys are playing cricket.
5. You are my friend.
6. They have taken their meal.

A finite verb agrees with its subject in number, person or tense. This is known as subject-verb agreement or agreement of the verb with its subject.

Read the following rules and examples carefully to understand subject-verb agreement.

1. A singular subject takes a singular verb and a plural subject takes a plural verb.

Examples:

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| (a) The baby is sleeping. | (d) They read a book. |
| (b) The babies are sleeping. | (e) I am waiting for you. |
| (c) He reads a book. | (f) We are waiting for you. |

2. When two or more nouns or pronouns are joined by 'and', and they represent two separate persons or things, the verb used should be plural.

Examples:

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|---|--|
| (a) Seeta and Geeta are going to market. | (c) You and he have taken your lunch. |
| (b) Gold and Platinum are precious metals. | (d) Time and tide wait for none. |

3. When two or more nouns or pronouns are joined by 'and', but they refer to or represent a single persons, thing or concept, the verb should be singular.

Examples:

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|--|---|
| (a) Early to bed and early to rise is a good habit. | (b) Rice and curry is my favourite meal. |
| (c) The horse and carriage is ready. | (d) My friend, guide and philosopher is my father. |

4. When two or more singular subjects are connected by 'or' or 'nor' the verb should be singular.

Examples: (a) Either Kunal or his friend **has** broken the window,
(b) Neither the milkman or his son **is** ploughing the field.

5. When a singular and a plural subject is connected by 'or' or 'nor', the plural subject is kept near the verb and the verb agrees with the plural subject.

Examples: (a) Either Kunal or his friends **have** broken the window.
(b) Neither the milkman or his sons **are** ploughing the field.

6. When the subjects joined by 'or' or 'nor' are pronouns of different persons, the verb should agree with the pronoun that is nearer the verb.

Examples:

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|---|--|
| (a) Either you or I am to blame. | (b) Neither you nor he is mistaken. |
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Exercise: Fill in the blanks with correct form of verb.

1. Children.....(is/am/are) playing in the ground at this time.
2. He always.....(help/helps) others.
3. I.....(is/am/are) a student.
4. Butterflies..... (has/have) beautiful wings.
5. My teacher..... (has/have) corrected my notebook.
6. Bread and butter(was/were) given to us as breakfast.
7. George and John..... (is/am/are) best friends.
8. Either Kate or her friends (has/have) kept these books here.
9. Neither Jatin nor his father.....(have/has) a red car.
10. Either you or he.....(have/has) received the message.

7. When a Noun or a Pronoun is joined with another noun (s) or pronoun (s) using the words, 'with', 'as well as', 'along with', 'no less than', 'together with', 'besides' or 'and not', the verb agrees with the one introduced first in the sentence.

Examples:

- (a) The coach, with all the players, is practising in the field.
- (b) The players, as well as the coach, are practising in the field.
- (c) Abhinav, no less than his colleagues, is very honest.
- (d) Geetika, and not her sisters, has baked the cake.
- (e) I, as well as they, am sick of his behaviour.

8. The words such as 'each', 'every', 'either', 'neither', 'many a', 'everyone', 'everybody', 'somebody' 'one of', 'none of' etc. take a singular verb.

- Examples:** (a) Each child **was** given a candy. (b) Everybody **wants** to be appreciated.
(c) Somebody **has** stolen my purse. (d) One of my friends **has** settled in the USA.
(e) Many a student **was** playing in the playground.

9. If two singular subjects joined by 'and' are qualified by 'each' or 'every', they take a singular verb.

- Examples:** (a) Each hour and each minute is precious.
(b) Every man and every woman desires happiness.

10. Error of Proximity: When the subject is a phrase, the verb must agree with the subject proper instead of the word which is near the verb. The error of making the verb agree with the word near it is called the error of proximity.

- Examples:** (a) The **attitude** of the officers **is** friendly. (b) A **list** of the candidates **was** prepared.

11. Some nouns which appear to be singular, but are treated as plural, take a plural verb.

- Examples:** (a) The cattle **are** grazing in the field. (b) Six dozen **cost** rupees five hundred.
(c) The people **were** shouting.

12. Some nouns appear to be plural, but they take a singular verb.

- Examples:** (a) Politics **is** a dirty game. (b) The news of his arrival **has** come.
(c) The wages of sin **is** death. (d) Mathematics **is** my favourite subject.

13. Collective nouns like committee, government, jury, panel etc. take singular verb when these nouns are used in the sense of a single unit or one whole; and plural verb when the individuals making the whole are considered separately.

- Examples:** (a) The jury **was** unanimous in its stand on the issue.
(b) The jury **were** divided on this controversial issue.

14. If a plural noun is used as a name of some singular object or collective unit, the verb that follows will be singular.

Examples: (a) The Arabian Nights **was** translated by Richard Burton.
(b) Gulliver's Travels **is** an interesting book.

15. When a plural noun denoting some specific quantity or amount is taken in the sense of a whole, the verb it takes should be generally singular. If it is not taken as a single whole, it takes a plural verb.

Examples: (a) Eight months **is** a long time. (b) Fifty miles **is** a long distance.
(c) Five thousand rupees **is** a great sum. (d) Five thousand rupees **were** paid to the workers.

16. When two nouns joined by 'and' take a single article, they refer to the same person and take a singular verb, when they take two separate articles; they refer to two persons and take a plural verb.

Examples: (a) The poet and novelist **was** honoured.
(b) The poet and the novelist **were** honoured.

17. Certain phrases such as, 'a lot of', 'a plenty of', 'some of', 'most of', 'half of', 'all the' etc. take a singular verb if followed by a singular noun; a plural verb if followed by a plural noun.

Examples: (a) A lot of money **was** wasted on this project.
(b) A lot of books **were** scattered in the room.

Exercise: Fill in the blanks with the correct forms of Verbs.

1. Arun and Aman.....(is/are) friends.
2. I(was/were) present there.
3. My friend..... (like/likes) bananas.
4. All the children(is/are) in the park.
5. You(is/are) my friend.
6. The students(has/ have) learnt their lessons.
7. The baby(is/am) sleeping.
8. The babies.....(is/ are) sleeping.
9. He(drive/drives) a car.
10. I(is/am) writing a letter.
11. John and Joseph.....(is/ are) going to London.
12. Silver and Aluminium(is/ are) useful metals.
13. My father and I.....(am/are) watering the plants.
14. You and he.....(has/ have) taken your lunch.
15. Time and Tide(wait/waits) for none.
16. Rice and Curry(are/is) my favourite meal.

17. Either Rajesh or his brother..... has/have taken your book.
18. Neither the farmer nor his sons..... (is/are) ploughing the field.
19. Either you or I(are/am) to blame.
20. Neither you nor he.....(are/ is) mistaken.
21. Each child(were/was) given a candy.
22. Everybody(want/wants) to become rich.
23. Somebody(has/have) stolen my horse.
24. One of my friends.....(has/have) topped the class.
25. Many a cat.....(was/were) drinking milk.

Exercise: Tick the correct option in the following sentences.

1. The quality of these apples (is/are) very good.
2. A list of the candidates (was/were) prepared.
3. The cattle (is/are) grazing in the field.
4. A black and white cow (is/are) standing in the field.
5. Some of the students (has/have) joined the club.
6. Mathematics (is/are) an important subject.
7. The news of his arrival (have/has) come.
8. The wages of sin (is/are) death.
9. Slow and steady (win/wins) the race.
10. One of the players (are/is) injured.
11. The jury (was/were) divided on this controversial issue.
12. Gulliver's Travels (is/are) an interesting book.
13. Fifty miles (is/are) a long distance.
14. A sum of five thousand rupees (were/was) paid to the workers.
15. The scientist and the philosopher (was/were) dead.
16. A number of people (has/have) gathered there.
17. Dozens of oranges (is/are) lying scattered.
18. Each of the participants (was/were) given a certificate.
19. The committee (has/have) taken its decision.
20. All the members of the committee (was/were) present there.
21. The coaches, with all the teams, (is/are) practising in the field.
22. Gymnastics (is/are) a popular sport.
23. Whose poultry (is/are) there in this village?
24. The only means of transport to reach the village (is/are) boats.
25. The police (is/are) looking into the matter.